Foreign languages

Hello everyone, and welcome to this sixth episode of the Cottongue Podcast!

[00:00:12] I hope you're well and feeling fit! I'm very well because spring has finally arrived where I live, in Warsaw! The weather is lovely, the sun is shining, and temperatures are a little warmer: it's between ten and twenty degrees. And what's the weather like where you are? Is it good or bad? And what season is it? Spring, summer, autumn or winter?

[00:00:49] Whatever the season, it's a good time to listen to a podcast in French!

[00:00:57] Today, we're going to talk about foreign languages. You know that a language can be either your mother tongue, the one you learn as a child, or a foreign language. If your parents are Spanish, your mother tongue is Spanish because it's the first language you learn. It's also possible to have several mother tongues. For example, if your father is German but your mother is Italian, you'll probably learn two mother tongues: German and Italian.

[00:01:42] Then, at school, we learn other languages, foreign languages. In France, the most popular foreign languages at school are English, which is compulsory, German, Spanish and Italian.

[00:02:01] You may know this, but French people are known for being bad at languages. We often hear that French people can't speak English. And it's true! In rankings that test English proficiency in Europe, France often comes last. There is an examination called TOEFL to certify English proficiency, and in the TOEFL ranking, France is twenty-fifth! That isn't a very good position.

[00:02:38] But fortunately, things are changing! Among young people and in big cities, more and more people can speak English. Now some tourists complain, they're unhappy, because when they try to speak French with a Parisian, for example, the Parisian replies in English to be polite. But some tourists think that's rude. It's funny: when French people reply in English, tourists think it's rude, but when they reply in French, sometimes they think that's rude too!

[00:03:26] The problem is that some French people still think learning a language is useless. Thirty percent of French people think they don't need to know how to speak a foreign language. That's a shame! But it's true that some people can live perfectly well knowing only their mother tongue if they live in a small town, don't travel and don't need another language at work. It's increasingly rare, but it still exists. And unfortunately, many French people think learning a language is a chore. A chore is something we're obliged to do but that is unpleasant, tiresome, like cleaning the house or doing the laundry. We don't like doing these things, but we have to do them. So many French people find learning English boring and tiresome. They don't enjoy doing it. And when we feel obliged to do something we don't like, naturally we lack motivation and often don't get good results.

[00:04:55] When I began giving French lessons in Warsaw, I was very surprised. I was very surprised because my students were learning French for pleasure, rather than out of obligation. Often, my students don't need French for their work, and they aren't planning to

move to a French-speaking country either, a country where people speak French. French has no practical use for them! They simply like the French language and want to be able to speak it. In my opinion, that's the best way to learn a language: when you do it for pleasure and out of love for that language.

[00:05:47] And you, for what reasons are you learning French? Do you need it for your work? Is it because you love French literature or cinema? Or perhaps because you have French friends? Tell me why. I'm very curious to know! I'm learning Polish because I live in Poland, and also because my girlfriend is Polish. Love is a very good source of motivation, believe me!

[00:06:28] And today, I'm going to give you lots of other good reasons to learn a foreign language! Reasons that concern our brain and our tolerance, rather than our professional career!

[00:06:44] Do you want to know why learning a foreign language is good for our brain and makes us more tolerant?

[00:06:53] Yes? Then let's go!

[00:07:01] Since the early 2000s, there have been many studies of bilingual people. A bilingual person, as you know, is someone who knows two languages. Scientists want to know whether there are differences between the brains of bilingual people and those of monolingual people. They want to know whether their brains work differently.

[00:07:33] To compare bilingual and monolingual people, scientists often use children. For example, children who are bilingual because their parents speak two different languages.

[00:07:48] In the past, scientists thought speaking two languages was a disadvantage for children. Why? I'm going to explain it to you.

[00:08:00] When we speak two languages, we have two systems operating in our brain. Even when we use one language, the second isn't inactive. For example, when I speak French with my friends, sometimes I think of English words that express an idea I have better. So even though I'm using French, my English "system" is operating in my head.

[00:08:33] Because of this, scientists thought the second system, the second language, could hinder, could disturb bilingual children. They thought the second language created confusion and that these children couldn't concentrate. And if children can't concentrate, they can't get good marks, good results at school.

[00:09:07] But thanks to recent scientific experiments, we know all that was wrong. In reality, bilingual children learn more easily than others. They can concentrate on one problem and then quickly move on to another. They're better at solving problems. "To solve" is a verb meaning "to find a solution".

[00:09:38] Scientists don't yet know why bilingual children have better abilities. And you, do you have an idea? Do you know why bilingual children have better abilities?

[00:09:57] Some researchers think bilingual children are more accustomed to monitoring their surroundings and adapting quickly. It's like when you drive a car: you have to pay attention to your surroundings, the other cars in front of and behind you, pedestrians and so on. You're concentrating on the road, but you're also monitoring things around you. Bilingual children have to do the same. They need to pay attention to the people around them to know which language to speak. For example, they have to speak one language with their father and another with their mother. They must be ready to change languages quickly, to react quickly. So their brain is accustomed to this exercise. It's trained. Their brain adapts more quickly, and it doesn't require much effort. It's easy for them, almost natural.

[00:11:18] Fortunately, this isn't true only for bilingual children. People who learn a second language later in life also develop their brain. They learn to adapt and switch from one language to another. But it requires a little more work and effort. It isn't as easy as it is for bilingual children.

[00:11:53] When you exercise regularly, your body ages more slowly. You stay in shape longer. Well, it's the same with your brain. When you train your brain, it stays young longer. And learning a foreign language is an excellent exercise for the brain and memory. Scientific studies have shown that people who speak several languages are less affected by diseases such as Alzheimer's, the disease that causes memory loss.

[00:12:41] Would you like me to explain why? When you learn a language, your brain has to work hard. When I speak Polish with someone for an hour, afterwards I'm very tired, as tired as when I go to the gym! My brain has to work hard. It has to create connections. But fortunately, it becomes easier and easier! The more we practise, the easier it becomes, because the connections in our brain start working. And the more connections there are in our brain, the more slowly it ages. That's good news, isn't it?

[00:13:39] Finally, other studies have shown that learning a foreign language has a positive effect on our creativity. Did you know that the author Ernest Hemingway spoke fluent Spanish and French in addition to English? Perhaps that helped him win the Nobel Prize in Literature.

[00:14:11] In short, you can see that there are many advantages for our brain.

[00:14:17] So if you want your brain to stay in shape longer, keep learning French!

[00:14:32] Besides all these advantages for our brain, learning a foreign language also improves our tolerance. "Tolerance" is the ability to respect other people, to respect their freedom, their opinions and so on.

[00:14:54] Why do you think learning a language improves our tolerance?

[00:15:04] In fact, there are two explanations, two factors that explain this.

[00:15:11] The first explanation is that this learning opens our eyes to other ways of doing things. In French we say "être ouvert d'esprit", to be open-minded, which means being tolerant and respecting differences. "To be open-minded".

[00:15:36] When we learn a foreign language, we see that people communicate differently, that they express their ideas in different ways. We understand that they have a different culture and that our culture isn't the only one in the world. Often, when I see French tourists on holiday, I hear them comparing everything with France. They say, "Here people eat like this, but in France we eat in a different way." Or, "There's no bread in the restaurants, whereas in France there's always bread at a restaurant." For these tourists, it's sometimes difficult to accept these differences. They don't understand why everyone doesn't do things like French people. They think it's strange.

[00:16:47] We also have many stereotypes about other nationalities, other countries. A stereotype is an idea we accept without reflecting, without thinking. We also call it a "cliché". These stereotypes are often misunderstandings. We don't understand why people in another country behave differently, so we invent a stereotype. For example, French people work thirty-five hours a week. That's the legal working time. So people in other countries sometimes think French people are lazy, that they don't like working. But in fact, it's simply a matter of political choice. It was the Government that adopted the thirty-five-hour week for economic reasons, for example to reduce unemployment. But that doesn't mean French people are lazy. And what's more, when they work, French people are very productive, very efficient!

[00:18:16] When we learn a foreign language, we understand that many stereotypes are false. We adopt a new way of thinking to understand others. We understand why foreigners behave this way, why they think this way or that, why there's no bread at a restaurant! We know that no culture is "better" than others. We simply accept different cultures and respect them.

[00:18:54] So that was the first explanation. Learning a foreign language makes us more open-minded.

[00:19:07] The second explanation concerns our ability to adapt. Having a good ability to adapt means being able to adapt to a situation we don't know.

[00:19:26] For a person who travels a lot, it's easy to adapt to a new country. They're accustomed to living in different environments, eating different types of food and being surrounded by people of a different nationality.

[00:19:49] By contrast, for a person who never travels, it's very difficult! Generally, this person doesn't feel comfortable abroad. They feel lost. They aren't accustomed to this kind of situation. Perhaps they're even afraid. They have trouble adapting. To "have trouble" doing something means to have difficulty doing it, that it's difficult to do. For example, "I have trouble understanding you" means it's difficult for me to understand what you're telling me.

[00:20:41] When we speak several languages, we have a better ability to adapt. For example, we can read a text even if we don't understand all the words. If there are words we don't know, we try to understand the sentence through its context. We don't concentrate on the words we don't know, but on those we understand. And the more languages we know, the easier it becomes.

[00:21:13] The first time, it’s rather complicated. But afterwards, learning new languages becomes easier and easier. We adapt more quickly to a new system. We’re accustomed to this kind of situation. It doesn’t frighten us or make us panic.

[00:21:38] By contrast, people who don’t know other languages tend to panic when they find themselves in this kind of situation. They focus on words they don’t know and develop a mental block. They lack flexibility. They think it’s impossible to understand.

[00:22:03] In France, for example, we learn English for at least seven years. Seven years is a long time! But when they have to speak English with someone, French people think it’s impossible. They think they lack words, and they start to panic. Because they aren’t accustomed to this kind of situation, they prefer giving up to trying. The situation is so stressful that these people just want to stop and escape from it, to leave!

[00:22:45] To summarise, we can say that bilingual people, who speak two languages, or multilingual people, who speak several languages, generally have more self-confidence. That means they believe in their potential and their abilities. They know they’re capable of doing new things. And this doesn’t concern only languages. It concerns their lives in general. They aren’t afraid to take risks, to step outside their comfort zone. They have a different attitude from people who speak only one language.

[00:23:35] The last advantage I want to tell you about is the most surprising. What if I told you that speaking several languages lets you live several lives? Would you believe me if I told you that?

[00:23:55] Several studies have shown that a person’s personality changes according to the language they speak. Of course, that doesn’t mean these people are like Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde. But their way of thinking changes slightly. I, for example, am often more open and energetic when I speak English. I think that’s because Americans are very charismatic. They have a different style from French people, a warmer and more emotional style. So when I speak English, I copy that style unconsciously. “Unconsciously” means “without being aware of it”. You do something without thinking about it, unconsciously.

[00:24:58] French people are more rational. They think what we say is more important than the way we say it. We have an expression for that: “le fond et la forme”, substance and form. Substance is the content, the subject matter. Form is the style, the way of expressing something. So in French, substance is often more important than form.

[00:25:34] In short, I, for example, have two personalities: my French personality and my English personality. What’s more, I’m also starting to have a new personality, my Polish personality, since I’m learning Polish! And I think that when we have several personalities, it’s a little like living several lives.

[00:26:04] And you, do you have several personalities? What is your French personality like?

[00:26:18] To conclude, we’ve seen that there are many advantages to learning a foreign language. First, it’s good training for our brain. When we learn a new language, our brain works hard and becomes more efficient. We can solve problems more easily. We also have a

better memory. What’s more, these advantages apply throughout our lives. Next, learning a language makes us more tolerant because we know other cultures, other ways of living. We become capable of communicating with people who are different from us. People who know several languages also have a better ability to adapt. They aren’t afraid of new situations. They like trying things.

[00:27:25] And finally, the last argument is that speaking different languages lets us have different personalities and therefore live several lives.

[00:27:43] There we are, we’re coming to the end of this podcast. I hope it’s made you want to continue learning French, and other languages too. Why not!

[00:27:57] As usual, you can find the transcript of this podcast on my website, cottongue.com/podcast. That makes it easier to understand what I’m saying. Go to my website, cottongue.com/podcast, and you’ll find all the transcripts. Thank you, everyone, thank you for listening to me. I’m very happy because there are more and more listeners to this podcast. For next week, I’ve prepared a very interesting topic for you: we’ll talk about conspiracy theories. So if you want to know everything about conspiracy theories, join me next week. Thank you, and see you soon!